

RAG didn't die. It got promoted.

Retrieval went from a step in a fixed pipeline to a tool the agent decides to call. The search & retrieval year, before Elastic{ON} New York.

2025 · ITS ROLE

~~A pipeline step~~

runs once · before the model
every question, same path



2026 · ITS ROLE

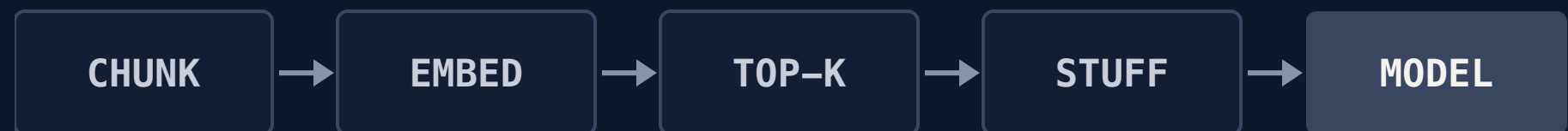
A tool the agent calls

the agent decides
when · where · how often

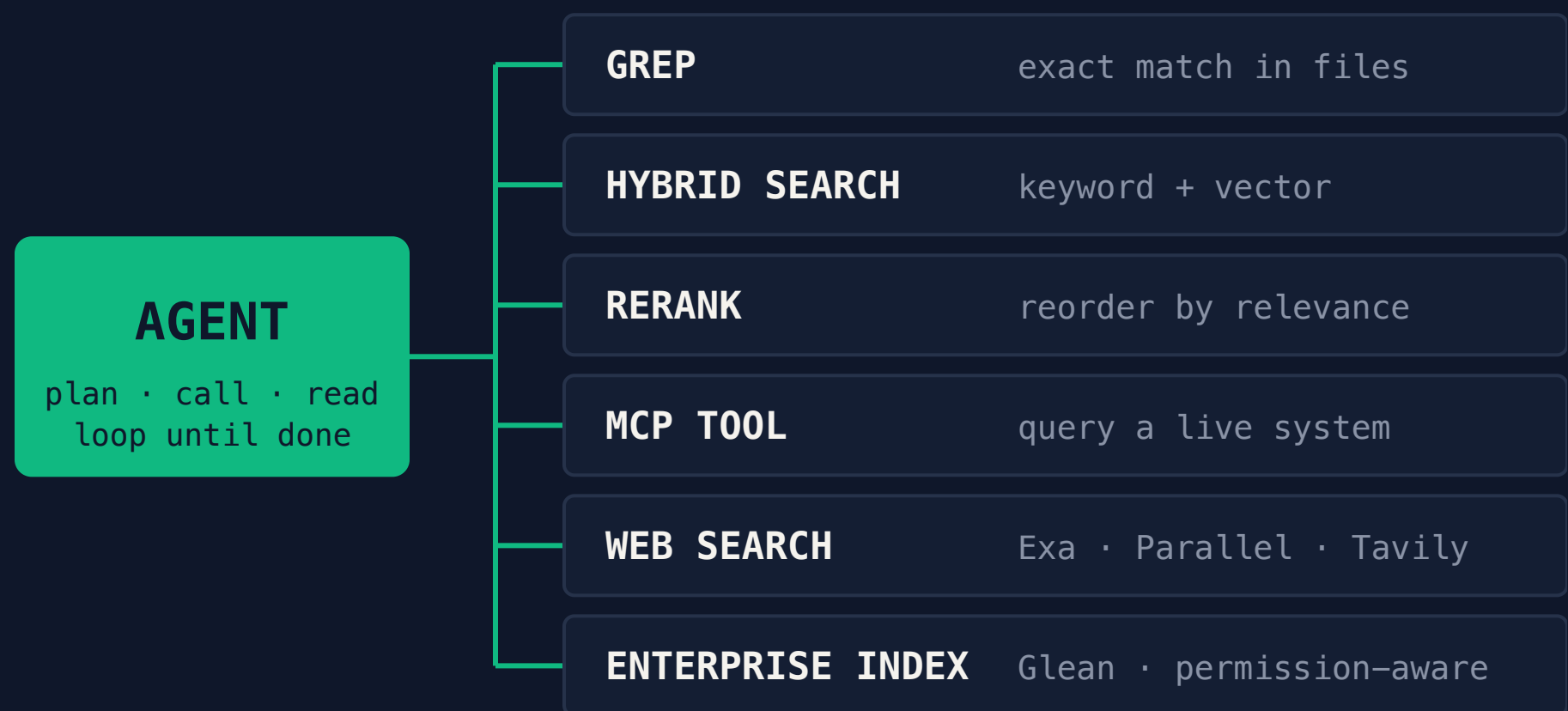
WHAT CHANGED · THE MECHANISM

From pipeline to tool call

BEFORE · FIXED PIPELINE, ONCE PER QUESTION



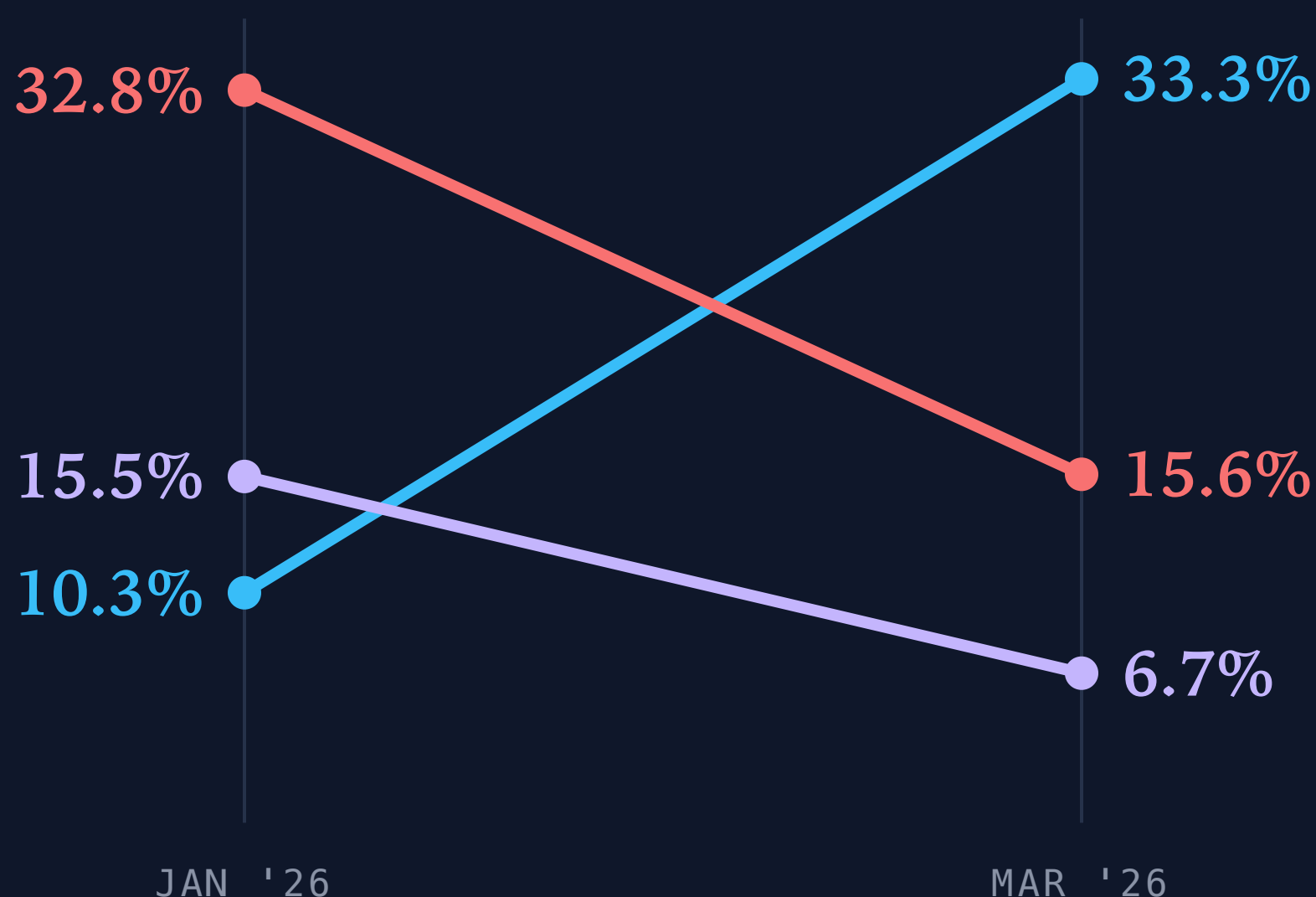
AFTER · THE AGENT CHOOSES, EVERY STEP



Pattern: Turnbull, "Agentic search is having a grep moment," Apr 2026;
Anthropic, context engineering for agents.

One quarter, three lines

- HYBRID RETRIEVAL INTENT
- LONG CONTEXT AS MAIN ARCHITECTURE
- INVESTMENT IN RETRIEVAL EVALUATION



Hybrid intent tripled. Evaluation was cut in half.

Source: VB Pulse, "The retrieval rebuild," 2026. Monthly enterprise survey, n≈50 per month.

The retrieval year, dated

● launch / signal ● money

- JAN 22 Elastic Agent Builder GA, MCP + A2A
- FEB 10 Nebius buys Tavily • \$275M
- MAR 13 1M-token context at standard price
- APR 6 "Agentic search is having a grep moment"
- APR 28 Parallel raises at \$2B
- MAY 20 Exa valued at \$2.2B
- MAY 28 Glean crosses \$300M ARR
- AUG 27 37% of Elastic's \$100K+ customers on AI
- SEP 11 Elastic serverless vector database
- OCT 8 Elastic{ON} New York

Sources: Elastic; Anthropic; Turnbull; SiliconANGLE; Bloomberg; TechCrunch (Glean, company-reported); PYMNTS. Elastic 37% vs ~21% a year earlier, Q1 FY27 call.

Who checks what it chose?

When the agent decides what to retrieve,
what do you measure: recall, citations, or
nothing yet?

Elastic{ON} New York

Convene · 30 Hudson Yards

Thu Oct 8 · Search, Security, Observability

Next: what the room said · 2/2